

‘We aren’t chasing overnight success’

Zoho VP **Praval Singh** on privacy and Arattai competing with WhatsApp

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We are in the middle of India’s fast-evolving messaging app landscape, and Zoho’s Arattai has found itself at the centre of attention. What began as a quietly developed side project over four years ago within one of India’s most respected software companies has now crossed 10 million downloads on the Google Play Store, sparking debate about whether a homegrown platform can realistically challenge the dominance of WhatsApp, Google and other tech giants.

However, Praval Singh, VP of Marketing and Customer Experience at Zoho, believes that the conversation is not about chasing trends or riding short-term hype. ‘We are not a start-up that came out two weeks ago,’ he says. ‘We’ve been around for nearly three decades. Whatever we build today has a strong foundation: our technology infrastructure, data centres and a global user base of 130 million.’

From B2B expertise to consumer-grade communication

Talking about the app, Singh said

Arattai did not emerge out of thin air. He stated that the app draws on Zoho’s long-standing experience in building communication tools for businesses, such as Zoho Cliq, a full-fledged messaging, voice and video platform that has powered enterprise communication for almost years.



Praval Singh
VP of Marketing & Customer
Success, Zoho

‘Arattai was an attempt to build a consumer app using the same infrastructure, but with different features, capabilities and user experience. The underlying platform, technology and R&D already exist,’ Praval Singh added.

The sudden surge in downloads, he adds, has prompted Zoho to expand capacity and scale its servers, but the company’s approach still remains measured. ‘We’re not trying to replace an existing app because these are habit-forming products. We believe if we stay true to our core values: privacy, value and simplicity, people will stay,’ Singh stated.

Privacy as a principle, not a checkbox

When asked about end-to-end encryption and balancing user privacy with government compliance, Singh is clear.

‘Encryption is already present in transit and at rest. End-to-end encryption was always planned, and we’ll be implementing it soon,’ he said.

However, for him, privacy is more than just encryption protocols; it is an integral part of Zoho’s DNA. ‘Privacy is more than just a checkmark on a feature list. It is about the company’s ethos. Zoho generates no revenue from advertising. We do not monetise or sell user data. As a result, hundreds of thousands of businesses around the world trust us.’

When it comes to cooperating with laws in different regions, Singh says, ‘We play by the law of the land, whether it’s India, the United States or Europe. Some regions require that data not leave the country, which is why we have invested in 18 data centres worldwide. But our stance on user privacy remains unchanged.’

Onboarding users in a crowded space

Arattai’s biggest challenge is obvious: breaking user habits in a market that has been long dominated by Meta and Google. Singh acknowledges this, saying, ‘Consumer apps are based on habits. For Arattai to become a daily driver, it must provide value.’

That value, he says, will come from features that are tailored specifically to Indian users, such as expanded group management for communities, societies or large families, as well as future integrations like payments. ‘We already support nine Indian languages and are considering dialect diversity. We want to create something that will stick,’ Singh said.

The plan is long-term. We need to be patient. Every day, our engineers work tirelessly to improve the experience. And, as with UPI, adoption will grow organically as people realise the convenience and value,’ he added. 

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